

ERMS

Expense Reimbursement Management System

User Guide & Help
KSCAA Tech RRC 2026 - Group 8
Prepared July 2026

Starting the Application (Windows)

1. Clone or copy the `ERMS_final` folder, then double-click `run.bat` inside it.
2. The launcher checks your system automatically: it installs Node.js and PostgreSQL if either is missing, installs the project's dependencies, sets up the database (creating it and applying migrations if needed), seeds the demo accounts, and starts both the backend and frontend servers in their own windows.
3. If PostgreSQL was already installed on your machine under a different password than this project expects, the launcher detects that automatically and asks you to type the correct password once - it then saves it and continues on its own. No manual configuration file editing is required.
4. Once you see **"Done - servers are starting in their own windows"**, open `http://localhost:5173` in your browser. Keep the two server windows open while using the application; closing either one stops that server.

You can re-run `run.bat` any time - every step is skipped automatically if it's already done.

Getting Started

1. Open the application in your browser and go to the login page.
2. Enter the email and password given to you by your Admin.
3. **First login:** you will be asked to set a new password immediately, before you can do anything else. Choose a password that is at least 8 characters and includes an uppercase letter, a lowercase letter, a number, and a special character - the screen shows you exactly which of these your new password is missing as you type.
4. Forgot your password? Click **Forgot password?** on the login screen and follow the instructions to reset it.
5. Your session will automatically end after a period of inactivity, for security. Simply log in again to continue.

For Employees

Submitting a New Claim

1. Go to **New Claim** in the left menu.
2. Choose a category (Travel, Food, Office Supplies, or Other), the date of the expense, the amount, and an optional description. Click **+ Add line item** for more than one expense in the same claim.
3. Attach at least one bill or receipt - **this is required**, the claim cannot be submitted without it.
4. Click **Submit Claim**. It now goes to your manager for approval.

Tracking Your Claims

Go to **Claim History** to see every claim you've submitted and its current status:

Status	What it means
Pending Manager Review	Submitted, waiting on your manager
Approved by Manager	Passed to Accounts for verification
Returned by Manager	Sent back to you to fix something - see below
Rejected by Manager / Rejected by Accounts	Declined, with a reason in remarks
Verified	Confirmed by Accounts, awaiting payment
Paid	Reimbursement has been processed

If Your Claim Is Returned

A **Resubmit** button appears next to any returned claim in Claim History. Fix whatever your manager's remarks asked for, then click it to send the claim back into their queue.

Notifications & Changing Your Password

Check **Notifications** for updates on your claims. You can change your password at any time from **Change Password** at the bottom of the left menu.

For Managers

1. **Approval Queue** lists every claim submitted by your direct reports that's waiting on you.
2. Click **Review** to see the full claim - line items, amount, and attached bills (click a bill's name to open it).
3. Enter your remarks (required for every decision) and choose one of:
 - **Approve** - sends it to Accounts for verification.
 - **Return** - sends it back to the employee to fix and resubmit.
 - **Reject** - ends the claim.
4. **Approval Summary** shows every decision you've made, filterable by Approved / Returned / Rejected, including what happened to the claim afterward (e.g. an approved claim that's since been paid). Export it to CSV from the button at the top of the screen.

Why can't I see or approve a claim from someone in my department?

Only an employee's specifically assigned manager can approve their claims - being in the same department isn't enough. If you believe you should be someone's manager, ask your Admin to check the assignment.

For Accounts

1. **Verification** lists every claim already approved by a manager.
2. Click **Run duplicate check** to check for a possible duplicate or repeated bill before verifying - a claim flagged as a possible duplicate cannot be verified until it's resolved.
3. Enter remarks and choose **Verify** or **Reject**.
4. **Payment Processing** lists every verified claim still awaiting payment ("pending payable"). Choose a payment mode (Bank Transfer, Cheque, or Cash) and click **Mark Paid**.
5. Use **Reports** to run Employee-wise, Department-wise, Monthly, Payment, or Rejected reports, and export any of them to CSV.

For Admin

Employees & Departments

Create departments first, then employees - every employee needs a department and a manager (except the CEO, who has none). Use **Reset Password** next to any employee to generate a one-time temporary password if they're locked out; they'll be required to change it at their next login. Use **Deactivate** to disable an account - if that person still has direct reports, you'll be asked to reassign those reports to someone else first.

Approval Matrix

Defines which role approves claims in a given amount range per department. Click **Edit** on any row to change it, or **Delete** to remove it.

Audit Log

Every action in the system - every claim submission, approval, payment, login, and password change - is recorded here automatically and cannot be edited or deleted. Filter by entity type, action, or date range, and click **Details** on any entry to see exactly what changed.

Frequently Asked Questions

Why do I have to change my password right after logging in?

Either this is your first time logging in, or an Admin reset your password for you. Either way, the system requires you to set your own new password before doing anything else, for security.

I forgot my password and can't log in at all - what do I do?

Click **Forgot password?** on the login page and enter your email. Follow the link/instructions shown to set a new password. If that doesn't work, ask your Admin to reset it for you.

Why was my claim rejected without me seeing it coming?

Check the remarks on that claim in Claim History - every rejection and return requires the reviewer to explain why, and that reason is always visible to you there.

My claim has been "Approved by Manager" for a while - why hasn't it been paid?

It still needs to be verified by Accounts and then marked paid - "Approved by Manager" is only the first of two checks. Once Accounts verifies it, it moves to "Verified" and then "Paid" once payment is processed.

Can I edit a claim after I've submitted it?

Not directly. If your manager returns it, you can fix the issue they noted and resubmit it. There is currently no way to edit a claim that's still awaiting review.

Why does the system say my session expired?

For security, a session ends automatically after a period of inactivity. Just log in again - your data and any submitted claims are safe.

Why can't I submit a claim without a bill attached?

Mandatory bill attachment is an internal control the system enforces - not just a form requirement. A claim genuinely cannot be submitted without at least one attachment.

run.bat asked me for a PostgreSQL password - what do I enter?

This only happens if PostgreSQL was already installed on your machine before you ran the launcher, under a different password than the project's default. Enter the password you use to log into your existing PostgreSQL installation. If you don't know it, you'll need to check with whoever set up PostgreSQL on that machine, or reinstall it.